PARACHUTE

Despite the successes achieved by Airborne forces, parachutes had serious drawbacks as a means of delivering men into combat. It was difficult to achieve an accurate drop under fire, at night, or in adverse weather conditions. Paratroopers were vulnerable during the descent, being both highly visible and unable to manoeuvre. They were also easy prey immediately after landing while freeing themselves from their gear. The trooper risked having too much equipment for a comfortable jump, yet too little for effective infantry operation once on the ground.

Riser or shoulder strap

Type T5 parachute
The T5 was the standard parachute used throughout World War II by the US. At first white and made of silk, they were later replaced by nylon in camouflage colours. Troopers jumped using static lines attached to the plane that automatically deployed the chute. Parachute gear was difficult to remove and the soldier often had to cut himself free from the webbing on landing.

Static line feeds out in zigzag motion before ripping pull-out panel from chute, deploying it

Belly band feeds through two loops on the emergency chute to secure it

Static line hook attaches to plane

B4 life preserver or "Mae West"
The Mae West (named after the shapely actress) was standard issue for the US Army Airforce and was adopted by troopers. They wore them underneath their harnesses when being dropped near water. However, this was more of a psychological than practical advantage: the parachute harness had to first be removed before inflating the vest, and this was difficult to achieve in the water.

Strap secured down the back

Manual inflation valve

Rubberized canvas

Pull-out panel covering main parachute attaches to static line

Canvas

Saddle for trooper to sit in



Musette bag clips to front of harness



Mae West worn beneath harness



Emergency chute showing release handle